

B0B04B22 - Anglický jazyk B2-2

WEEK 5

Introduction to Articles*

Countable and Uncountable Nouns** & Using Adjectives with Countable and Uncountable Nouns

In academic English, **articles (a, an, the)*** are crucial for clarity and precision. They indicate whether a noun is specific or general, which is vital for conveying ideas accurately and professionally. Mastering article usage ensures that readers can easily understand the intended meaning and follow the flow of your writing. In academic and professional settings, precise language is essential. Proper article usage contributes to a polished and credible tone.

In academic English, understanding **countable and uncountable nouns**** is crucial for accurate grammar and clear communication. Countable nouns represent items that can be counted (e.g., "book," "chair"), while uncountable nouns refer to things that cannot be counted as individual units (e.g., "water," "information"). This distinction dictates the use of determiners (like "many" vs. "much") and verb conjugations, directly impacting the correctness and clarity of writing and speech.

Countable nouns require determiners like "a," "an," "many," or "few," while uncountable nouns use "much," "less," or "a little". For example, you'd say "many books" but "much information".

The verb form must agree with the noun's countability. For countable nouns, you use plural verbs in the plural form (e.g., "The books are on the table"). For uncountable nouns, you use singular verbs (e.g., "The information is helpful").

Using the correct countability helps avoid ambiguity and ensures your message is easily understood.

Introduction to Articles (A, AN, THE or NOTHING (X))

Read the following story, and decide if you need to use "a" "an" "the" or nothing (X) for each of the blank spaces (1 - 32).

I am from (1) _____ Seattle, (2) _____ Washington. (3) _____ Seattle is (4) _____ city in (5) _____ United States. It is near (6) _____ border with (7) _____ Canada in (8) _____ northwest corner of (9) _____ USA. I live in (10) _____ town called (11) _____ Olympia, which is not far from (12) _____ Pacific Ocean. I live in (13) _____ house on (14) _____ street in (15) _____ countryside. (16) _____ Street is called (17) _____ "Bear Street" and (18) _____ house is old - more than (19) _____ 100 years old! I am (20) _____ English teacher at (21) _____ school in (22) _____ center of (23) _____ town. I take (24) _____ bus to work every day as there is too much traffic to go by (25) _____ car. I usually have (26) _____ lunch at (27) _____ school. Sometimes, after (28) _____ work, we all go to (29) _____ Italian restaurant nearby. (30) _____ Restaurant is called (31) _____ "Luigi's". (32) _____ Italian food is great!

Here are some general rules for when to use "A", "AN", "THE" or NOTHING...

...look them over, then go back and see if you want to change any of your answers above.

a = indefinite article (not a specific object, one of a number of the same objects) with consonants. *

She has a dog. = one

* OR CONSONANT SOUNDS

I work in a factory. = one of a possible many

"She is A Unique person."

an = indefinite article (not a specific object, one of a number of the same objects) with vowels* (a, e, i, o, u).

Can I have an apple? = one

* OR VOWEL SOUNDS

She is an English teacher. = one of a possible many

"His first name begins with AN 'M'."

the = definite article (a specific object that both the person speaking and the listener know).

The car over there is fast.

The food is very good, isn't it?

The first time you speak of something use "a" or "an", the next time you repeat that object use "the".

I live in a house. The house is quite old and has four bedrooms.

I ate in a Chinese restaurant. The restaurant was very good.

DO NOT use an article with countries, states, counties or provinces, lakes and mountains except when the country is a collection of states such as "The United States".

He lives in Washington near Mount Rainier.

They live in northern British Columbia.

USE an article with large bodies of water, oceans, seas and rivers.

My country borders on the Pacific Ocean.

DO NOT use an article when you are speaking about things in general.

I like Italian cuisine.

She likes reading books.

DO NOT use an article when you are speaking about meals, certain places, and transport.

He has breakfast at home.

I go to university.

He comes to work by taxi. = 'He takes a taxi to work.'

→ go 'BY' (e.g., car, bus, train...)*

→ take 'A' (e.g., car, bus, train...) somewhere

* EXCEPTION = go 'ON' foot

PRACTICE: Articles (A, AN, THE or NOTHING):

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Look at the sentences below (1 - 15) and decide if you need to use "a" "an" "the" or nothing (X) for each of the blank spaces.

- (1) I have never seen ____ UFO.
- (2) David is ____ best student in our class.
- (3) May I ask you ____ question?
- (4) What is ____ name of the next station?
- (5) I only have ____ hour for lunch.
- (6) ____ Newcastle is ____ town in ____ north of England.
- (7) That was ____ interesting film!
- (8) Anna was born in ____ Italy but she lives in ____ Great Britain now.
- (9) ____ Gatwick Airport is in ____ southern England.
- (10) Does his name begin with ____ "F"?
- (11) I saw ____ bear when I was in ____ Yellowstone National Park.
- (12) I had ____ breakfast at 8:30 in ____ morning.
- (13) ____ Czech Republic, also known by its short-form name, ____ Czechia, is ____ landlocked country in ____ Central Europe.
- (14) Let's go for ____ drive in ____ country.
- (15) ____ United Kingdom includes ____ Northern Ireland and ____ Wales.

COUNTABLE and UNCOUNTABLE NOUNS

A **countable noun** means it can be counted. Often you can use an article ('a' or 'an') in front of the noun. Some countable nouns are **irregular** and follow different rules; one child or two children / one fish or two fish. Countable nouns can use quantifiers such as some, any, many, a few, a lot of, lots of, plenty of, etc...

An **uncountable noun** means it cannot be counted. It doesn't use an article ('a' or 'an') and is never made plural so information **NOT** informations. Countable nouns usually use a singular verb 'is' – Information is on our website. Uncountable nouns can use quantifiers like some, any, (not) much, little, and phrasal quantifiers of 'a piece of', 'a member of', 'an amount of', 'a type of', etc...

Uncountable nouns generally belong to one of the following categories:

LIQUIDS & GASES

- water
- coffee
- milk
- air
- oxygen

SUBJECTS

- French
- chemistry
- economics
- science
- math

SOLID & GRANULAR SUBSTANCES

- wood
- metal
- cheese
- sand
- rice

GROUPED CONCEPTS

- fruit
- money
- food
- vocabulary
- news

ENERGY WORDS & FORCES

- electricity
- sunshine
- radiation
- heat
- magnetism

INFORMATION & ABSTRACT CONCEPTS

- information
- advice
- education
- democracy
- intelligence

BOTH Countable & Uncountable Nouns

Some nouns can be **both** depending on the context. For example, coffee is uncountable as a product or a crop, but it is countable when it is a drink in cafe. Hair is uncountable on the head and explaining the colour, but it is countable as an individual hair.

Countable	Both	Uncountable
• A drink • I've drunk two coffees today	Coffee	• The product • Costa Rica grows coffee
• A single hair • I found a hair in my soup	Hair	• On the head • She has blonde hair

1) Countable nouns refer to things that can be counted such as objects, people, animals and processes.

Here are some examples: *participant, experiment, rat, questionnaire*

If a noun is countable, it means:

- we can count it (e.g. one participant, two participants);
- we can use numbers and the article *a/an* in front of it (e.g. 15 participants, a participant);
- it has a plural form (e.g. participants).

2) Uncountable nouns refer to things that cannot be counted such as materials, liquids and abstract concepts.

Here are some examples: *information, alcohol, funding, evidence, advice*

If a noun is uncountable, it means:

- we cannot count it (e.g. ~~one information, two informations~~);
- it is not possible to use numbers or the article *a/an* in front of it (e.g. ~~15 informations, an information~~);
- it generally does not have a plural form (e.g. ~~informations~~);
- it takes a singular verb (e.g. more information **is** needed).

3) It is often possible to guess whether a noun is countable or uncountable, but it is not always clear or logical. For example, fruit and vegetables are similar foods, but the noun *fruit* is usually uncountable, whereas the noun *vegetable* is countable.

To really be sure whether a noun is countable or uncountable, you need to consult a good dictionary.

4) Many nouns have a countable form as well as an uncountable form.

There is often a significant difference in meaning between the forms. In the example below, the uncountable form of *time* refers to time that can be measured in minutes, hours, etc. The countable form, on the other hand, refers to an occasion or event.

- *This is a complete waste of time* [U].
- *How many times* [C] *have you been to Spain?*

5) In other cases, the difference is more subtle.

In the example below, the uncountable form of *use* refers to the act of using something, whereas the countable form refers to the purpose for which something can be used.

- *The use* [U] *of antibiotics has increased significantly.*
- *This machine has many uses* [C].

Again, to really understand subtle differences in meaning, you need to consult a good dictionary.

6) If singularity is important when referring to an uncountable noun, you may need to use a phrase such as *a piece of* or *an item of*.

Here's an example: *This is an interesting piece of evidence.*

7) It is important that you know whether a noun you are using in your writing is countable or uncountable because it has an impact on the words you use with it.

Some words can only be used with countable nouns: *many, few, fewer, number*, etc.

Incorrect

- *Participants in the second group answered ~~less~~ questions.*

Correct

- *Participants in the second group answered **fewer** questions.*

Others can only be used with uncountable nouns: *much, little, less, amount*, etc.

Incorrect

- ~~**Few**~~ *attention was given to the results.*

Correct

- **Little** *attention was given to the results.*

Problematic Words - The Following Nouns are UNCOUNTABLE:

- | | |
|--|---|
| • ADVICE (...and advise [pronounced 'advi ze '] is a verb) | • INFORMATION |
| • CONSTRUCTION | • LUGGAGE (...but suitcase S & bag S = countable) |
| • EQUIPMENT | • RESEARCH (...researche S is outdated / no longer used – or highly specialized) |
| • EVIDENCE (...evidence S is outdated / no longer used – or highly specialized) | • STRENGTH (...exception = strength S & weaknesses) |
| • FEEDBACK | • STUFF (...but thing S = countable) |
| • FURNITURE (...but chair S & table S = countable) | • TRAFFIC (...traffic jam S) |
| • HEALTH | • VOCABULARY |
| • HOMEWORK (...homework assignment S) | • WEATHER |
| • HOUSEWORK | |

The Basic Rules: Countable and Uncountable Nouns

A countable noun is one that can be expressed in plural form, usually with an "s." For example, "cat—cats," "season—seasons," "student—students."

An uncountable noun is one that usually cannot be expressed in a plural form. For example, "milk," "water," "air," "money," "food." Usually, you can't say, "He had many moneys."

Countable and Uncountable Nouns with Adjectives

Most of the time, this doesn't matter with adjectives. For example, you can say, "The cat was gray" or "The air was gray." However, the difference between a countable and uncountable noun does matter with certain adjectives, such as "some/any," "much/many," and "little/few."

Some/Any: **Some** and **any** countable and uncountable nouns.

- "There is **some** water on the floor."
- "There are **some** students here."
- "Do you have **any** food?"
- "Do you have **any** apples?"

Much/Many: **Much** modifies only uncountable nouns. **Many** modifies only countable nouns.

- "We don't have **much** time to get this done."
- "**Many** Americans travel to Europe."

Little/Few: **Little** modifies only uncountable nouns.

- "He had **little** food in the house."
- "The doctor had **little** time to think in the emergency room."

Few modifies only countable nouns.

NOTE: **Few** is a quantifier used with plural countable nouns.

- "There are **few** doctors in town."
- "**Few** students like exams."

Without the article "a," **few** emphasizes a small number of something.

Adding the article removes the emphasis — **a few** means **some**.

The same rule applies to **little**, which is used with singular uncountable nouns.

Other basic rules

A lot of/lots of: **A lot of/lots of** are informal substitutes for much and many. They are used with uncountable nouns when they mean much and with countable nouns when they mean many.

- "They have **lots of** (much) money in the bank."
- "**A lot of** (many) Americans travel to Europe."
- "We got **lots of** (many) mosquitoes last summer."
- "We got **lots of** (much) rain last summer."

NOTE: **A lot** means very often or very much.

It is used as an adverb. It often comes at the end of a sentence and never before a noun.

A little bit of: **A little bit of** is informal and always precedes an uncountable noun.

- "There is **a little bit of** pepper in the soup."
- "There is **a little bit of** snow on the ground."

Enough: **Enough** modifies both countable and uncountable nouns.

- "There is **enough** money to buy a car."
- "I have **enough** books to read."

Plenty of: **Plenty of** modifies both countable and uncountable nouns.

- "They have **plenty of** money in the bank."
- "There are **plenty of** millionaires in Switzerland."

No: **No** modifies both countable and uncountable nouns.

- "There is **no** time to finish now."
- "There are **no** squirrels in the park."

PRACTICE - Countable / Uncountable Nouns:**[Page 5]**

Choose the best answer (a, b, c or d) for each of the following questions (1 - 15). *NOTE: This part looks EXACTLY*
There is ONLY ONE correct answer for each question. **CIRCLE** your answer (a, b, c or d). *like it will on the B2 Exam*

... EXCEPT there will be 5
instead of 15

- (1) I do not like black coffee. I usually have it with _____.
a) many milk b) a lot milk c) some milk d) the milk
- (2) The receptionist at the front desk gave me two _____.
a) informations b) of the information c) information d) pieces of information
- (3) My cousin is very beautiful. She has green eyes and _____.
a) long hair b) long hairs c) a long hair d) a bit long hair
- (4) How _____ have you got in the bank? Is it enough to buy a house?
a) many moneys b) many money c) much moneys d) much money
- (5) Can I borrow _____ from you? I've left mine at home and I want to write some notes.
a) paper b) a piece of paper c) a paper d) a slice of paper
- (6) How _____ did the teacher give us today? He always gives us a lot to do.
a) many homeworks b) many homework c) much homeworks d) much homework
- (7) Can you help me? I need _____.
a) the advice b) advice c) some advise d) an advice
- (8) It is surprising how _____ applied for the job.
a) many persons b) much people c) many people d) much of people
- (9) I have _____ in my house.
a) many new furnitures b) a new furniture c) some new furniture d) new furnitures
- (10) Do you speak _____?
a) the English b) any English c) some English d) much of English
- (11) How _____ traffic is on the highway now?
a) much traffic b) much traffics c) many traffic d) many traffics
- (12) There were _____ playing in the park yesterday.
a) some childs b) much children c) a lot of childrens d) many children
- (13) We are always grateful to receive _____ from our listeners.
a) feedback b) feedbacks c) a feedback d) some feedbacks
- (14) How _____ do we have before the test?
a) many times b) many time c) much time d) much of the time
- (15) Too _____ is dangerous for your health.
a) many salts b) many salt c) much salt d) much of salts

PRACTICE – Adjectives for Countable / Uncountable Nouns:

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Fill in the gaps in the sentences below (1 - 20) with the correct answer (a, b, c, or d).

CIRCLE your answer. There is ONLY ONE correct answer for each.

- (1) He still has _____ money, so he can go on holiday this year.
a) a little b) a few c) much d) little
- (2) _____ equipment is required to play hockey safely.
a) Many b) Enough c) A lot of d) Much
- (3) Look over there! I can see _____ people walking across the street.
a) no b) few c) much d) some
- (4) Were there _____ cars on the road?
a) a little bit of b) many c) some d) plenty of
- (5) Maria isn't very popular at school. She's got very _____ friends.
a) few b) much c) many d) little
- (6) Gina speaks very _____ English, but she knows a few words.
a) few b) much c) no d) little
- (7) She put too _____ salt into the soup.
a) many b) few c) much d) plenty of
- (8) This car uses hardly _____ petrol.
a) any b) much c) some d) enough
- (9) I've already been to Ireland _____ times.
a) a few b) a little c) some d) much
- (10) Caroline shows _____ interest in mathematics.
a) enough b) little c) few d) many
- (11) Jack phoned Julia at home, but there was _____ answer.
a) a little b) no c) some d) any
- (12) If there are _____ phone calls from the office, let me know.
a) many b) any c) enough d) some
- (13) Are there _____ desserts for everyone?
a) some b) any c) enough d) no
- (14) We've got _____ time before we need to leave for the airport.
a) any b) much c) plenty of d) no
- (15) Was there _____ food at the party?
a) some b) much c) a little d) many
- (16) She has _____ money. She really can't afford to go out.
a) any b) little c) a few d) much
- (17) Last month our company increased the profit. We found _____ new customers.
a) a little b) a lot c) much d) a few
- (18) If you have a fever you should drink _____ fluids.
a) many b) any c) some d) plenty of
- (19) This is a very difficult piece of music to play - it demands _____ concentration.
a) enough b) a lot of c) plenty of d) many
- (20) Would you like _____ of chocolate?
a) plenty b) some c) a little bit d) any